

Eurasian red squirrel

Around 90 species of tree squirrel live in forests around the world. Among them is the Eurasian red squirrel, which dwells in cool northern forests. Unlike most rodents, bushy-tailed squirrels are active during the day and they can often be spotted climbing trees.

Competing squirrels

In Britain, the introduced eastern gray squirrel has displaced the red squirrel from most of its original range (see panel below).

It now survives only in places where gray squirrel numbers are controlled.

Raising babies

In spring, female squirrels give birth to litters of up to six kits in tree holes or dreys (nests) made from twigs and leaves in the forest canopy.

Expansive forests

Red squirrels survive best in big expanses of forest. In places where forests are fragmented, their numbers drop.



Outcompeted

In parts of Europe, such as the UK and Italy, the eastern gray squirrel, introduced from North America, has driven out the native red squirrel because it is stronger and spreads a virus that can be lethal to its red cousins.



Squirreling nuts away

In fall, the red squirrel stores pine cones, acorns, nuts, and seeds by burying them. It uses memory and a good sense of smell to find them, even under snow in winter, helping it stay active and keep feeding.

Bushy-tailed rodent

The Eurasian red squirrel has a wide range, from western Europe to Siberia. It feeds on tree seeds, especially pine nuts. Its long, bushy tail can be used as a windbreak when the squirrel is feeding, or as shelter from rain or hot sun.